

Obsession: Case Study

Experiential Marketing vs Storytelling

Q. What made the movie go from 6 cr to 9,900 cr?

The growth was not the result of one lever. The film was strong, and the marketing turned that strength into a public event. In the words of Focus Features' Jason Cassidy, it came down to three things: a genuinely great film, incredible word-of-mouth, and a real sense of FOMO around it.

1. Experiential marketing that made the story real

- **One Wish Willow as a real product:** the cursed object from the film became something fans could actually buy and own. Vending machines also appeared in theatre lobbies.
- **Online + offline touchpoints:** interactive billboards in LA and NY, in-theatre stunts such as Nikki's handwritten sticky notes on bathroom mirrors, and popcorn tins.
- **Nikki's text line:** fans could text the character, who replied in character (with voice notes). She reminded people to buy tickets, follow her on Letterboxd and listen to her Spotify playlists. Marketing became an ongoing relationship, not a one-way message.
- **Eventizing the theatre:** Cassidy's mantra was "eventize, eventize, eventize". The aim was to make people feel they could not miss it on the big screen while competing with phones and couches.

2. Fan ownership and participation

- Creator-led launch: director Curry Barker and his 'That's a Bad Idea' audience were involved from day one, including a midnight screening at FocusFest that he introduced.
- Existing audiences were tapped early, for example a teaser attached to *Five Nights at Freddy's 2* to reach Blumhouse and horror fans.
- Fans made their own content: 'One Wish Willow Gone Wrong' TikToks, nail art, fan art and memes. This user-generated content kept the film in the feed long after the ad spend.

3. Word-of-mouth and the box-office snowball

- A 96% Rotten Tomatoes score and viral audience reactions (people posting before/after and in-theatre reactions) fuelled momentum.
- Ticket sales rose 39% in weekend two, and the film reportedly grew over its second and third weekends. That almost never happens outside Christmas. Once it became a cultural conversation, FOMO pulled in people who would not normally watch horror.
- Repeat viewing and group viewing: happy viewers brought friends back to watch them react.

Q. Storytelling or experiential marketing: which side do I favour?

I favour experiential marketing, built on top of good storytelling. Here is why:

- **Storytelling is the foundation, but it is not enough.** A great film gives people a reason to talk. Many great films still fail because nobody hears about them. Storytelling alone tells people about the world; it does not make them step into it.
- **Experiential marketing turns audiences into participants.** When fans text Nikki, buy the Willow or photograph a billboard, they are creating content and spreading the film for free. That is far

more credible than an ad, and it scales with social media.

- **It solves the modern problem of getting people out of the house.** Streaming, phones and couches are the competition. An experience creates urgency and FOMO that a trailer alone cannot.
- **The best experiential ideas are storytelling.** The text line, the Willow and the billboards were all drawn from the film's own world and characters, so they felt authentic rather than gimmicky.

	Storytelling	Experiential marketing
Role	Creates the hook and emotional pull	Lets people live the story
Strength	Depth, emotion, word-of-mouth base	Participation, shareability, FOMO
Risk	Passive; may not travel far	Feels gimmicky if disconnected from the story
In Obsession	'Be careful what you wish for' premise	Willow, Nikki's texts, billboards, lobby stunts

Conclusion

Obsession's rise from 6 cr to 9,900 cr came from a great story that was **turned into an experience** fans could take part in and own. Storytelling created the desire; experiential marketing converted that desire into shares, ticket sales and repeat visits. As the article puts it, the takeaway is to give audiences authentic, memorable and shareable moments that they can own.

Source: 'Inside the marketing strategy for Obsession', Link in Bio (Rachel Karten), interview with Jason Cassidy, Focus Features. The 6 cr / 125 cr / 9,900 cr figures are taken from your notes; the article itself does not state them.